

There was an obsessive quality about his passion for this beautiful stranger. Letters to her went unanswered and he moved into lodgings across the street from hers, only for her to promptly move out. Fortunately, Berlioz found a practical outlet for this fixation, using it as inspiration for his most famous creation, *Symphonie fantastique*.

Completed in 1830, this masterpiece is one of the most memorable landmarks of the Romantic movement. It has been hailed as a pioneering example of “program music”—a musical piece expressing themes and ideas that lie outside the scope of music itself and that are explained in program notes for the audience. Berlioz constructed his symphony in five movements, conveying the hopeless, unrequited love of a young musician. Plunged into despair, he takes opium, resulting in a series of outlandish visions, culminating in a march to the scaffold and an orgy at a witches’ sabbath. The object of the musician’s affections, his *idée fixe*, is represented by a melodic theme, which recurs in differing forms throughout the piece.

Harriet Smithson eventually heard a performance of the *Symphonie* in 1832 and, learning that it was about her, agreed to meet Berlioz. Romance blossomed and the couple were married in 1833. There was, however, no happy ending. Harriet gave birth to their son in 1834, but her own career was on the slide and the marriage soon turned sour. She became jealous and resentful of Hector’s growing success and turned increasingly to drink. They eventually parted and Berlioz took a new mistress, Marie Recio.